PINARAYI FACES THE HEAT

AN MLA'S EXPLOSIVE ALLEGATIONS EXPOSE THE DARK UNDERBELLY OF KERALA'S POLICE FORCE, DRAGGING EVEN THE CMO UNDER A CLOUD OF SUSPICION

By Jeemon Jacob



BURDEN OF PROOF
Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan

ANI

As the relentless monsoon rains lash Kerala's lush landscape, a different kind of storm is brewing in the state's political corridors. The Communist Party of India (Marxist)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) government finds itself caught in a deluge of controversy, with allegations as torrential as the downpour outside. It all began on August 30 with a press conference called by P.V. Anvar, a two-term Independent legislator from Nilambur in Malappuram district. Not only did the CPI(M)-backed legislator unleash a flood of accusations against a senior police officer with close ties to the Chief Minister's Office (CMO), he also charged CM Pinarayi Vijayan's political secretary P. Sasi, who handles the home department on his behalf, with shielding corrupt cops. Over the next few days, Anvar kept firing fresh salvos, even releasing allegedly incriminating recorded phone conversations as evidence against additional director general of police (ADGP) M.R. Ajith Kumar and his purported aide, superintendent of police (SP) Sujith Das.

The timing couldn't have been any worse for the Pinarayi government, which is already drawing flak for delaying the release of Hema Committee report that has triggered an avalanche of sexual harassment allegations against top Malayalam actors and filmmakers, including those close to the present regime. The latest string of allegations accuses the ADGP of links to gold smuggling rackets and criminal syndicates and of illegally acquiring wealth. It took Pinarayi three days to react and order a high-level inquiry even as leaders within both the ruling coalition and the Opposition mounted pressure on him, the latter even calling for his resignation. The whole episode has brought back memories of a similar controversy that had rocked the CMO in Pinarayi's first tenure in 2020. Back then, it was his principal secretary and key troubleshooter M. Sivasankar who was suspended and later arrested by the Enforcement Directorate for his alleged role in the sensational diplomatic channel gold smuggling case.

What is rocking the CM's boat

In the present case, the key piece of evidence that Anvar has offered is a recording of his alleged phone conversation with Sujith Das. Posted as SP in Pathanamthitta, Das had allegedly called the MLA to persuade him to withdraw a complaint in an illegal tree-felling case during his tenure in Malappuram. It was during this conversation that the SP, who himself is now caught in the eye of the storm, made some